

generous. When Waltham was dissolved in 1540, Tallis received 20 shillings in back-pay and a further 20 shillings “reward.”

The Chapel Royal

For many journeyman musicians, the Dissolution of the Monasteries was a disaster (see [box](#)), but Tallis’s talent and ambition helped secure his future. He soon found another job, as one of the “singing men” at Canterbury Cathedral. Two years later, in 1543, he landed his dream job in the Chapel Royal—an elite group of clergy and musicians attached to the royal household, who played wherever the monarch required. For a composer of sacred music, this was the absolute pinnacle of the profession—a secure, well-paid job, working with the finest musicians. Not surprisingly, Tallis remained with the group until he retired.

Change and adaptation

The composer’s greatest asset was his adaptability as he negotiated the tumultuous changes during the Reformation: services were held in English rather than Latin; and the chantries—where “soul-priests” sang Masses for the dead—were abolished, along with special services on saints’ feast-days. There was less music and it was more direct and simple. Elaborate polyphony was replaced by greater emphasis on psalms and anthems. Yet these changes were not permanent. Catholicism was revived during the reigns of Edward VI (1547–1553) and Mary (1553–1558), before Protestantism returned under Elizabeth I.

Tallis switched from one musical idiom to another with